



In addition to pride, also at stake would be a spot in the World Test Championship (WTC) final. Anything other than a series win would severely impair India's hopes of making a third consecutive final appearance, as the BGT is the side's last series of the current cycle.

Australia has a bit more leeway,



IN THE FACE OF A SOMEWHAT NEW-LOOK INDIAN LINE-UP, THE TEAM MIGHT, AT SOME POINT IN THE SERIES, RUE THE VOID LEFT BY CRISIS MEN CHETESHWAR PUJARA AND AJINKYA RAHANE



with the side scheduled for a Sri Lanka series away from home next year.

Irrespective of which way this series swings, it will be the final BGT for many stalwarts across both teams, with the next edition slated for early 2027. For India, it is nearly certain that Test mainstays like Ashwin, Jadeja, and Rohit won't be around by then.

The case is similar for Australia. The likes of Mitchell Starc, Nathan Lyon, and Smith are pushing towards the wrong side of the thirties, lending this upcoming series even more of a context.

For the last decade or so, these two sides, powered by a generation of superstars, have engaged in some of the most combative Test series in the sport's history. Rivalries sprung up for fun, narratives coalesced out of thin air, and battlelines were drawn. And once again, these two teams will lock horns during an Australian summer with everything at stake.

Wildcard: Nitish Kumar Reddy is in contention for the fast-bowling all-rounder's spot ahead of the first Test in Perth. GETTYIMAGES